

# Judge Briefing Guide

## hack the kitty 2026

High-level guidance for judging process, time commitment, and scoring expectations | Version: 11 June 2026

**Purpose:** This guide helps judges understand what they are committing to and how judging will work. It intentionally does not explain how to log in or use the platform; that remains covered by the separate platform guide.

## Commitment At A Glance

| Item                      | Expectation                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Active judging commitment | Be available for marking during 8-10 July 2026, the main three-day post-hackathon review window. Sponsor judges should ideally be able to cover at least two active judging days. |
| Overall judging period    | The public judging period runs 8-14 July 2026. Treat 11-14 July as potential calibration, tie-break, finalist, or organiser follow-up time unless told otherwise.                 |
| Time to reserve           | Planning estimate: block 3-4 focused hours per active judging day, with total load depending on the number of assigned submissions.                                               |
| Per-submission estimate   | Allow about 15-25 minutes for a normal first-pass review. Shortlisted, complex, or security-sensitive projects may need 25-40 minutes.                                            |
| What must be completed    | Score every submission assigned to you, save drafts only while reviewing, and submit final scores once you are confident. Final scores are locked.                                |

## Timeline

| Milestone           | Date / Window          | What It Means For Judges                                                                                              |
|---------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hackathon runs      | 24 June - 7 July 2026  | Participants build during this period. Judges do not need to review live work unless separately invited to a session. |
| Submissions close   | 7 July 2026, 22:00 BST | The judging set is prepared after the deadline. Late availability issues should be raised before this point.          |
| Main marking window | 8-10 July 2026         | Primary judging commitment. Judges review assigned projects and submit scores.                                        |
| Follow-up window    | 11-14 July 2026        | Organisers may use this period for score checks, finalist review, second-pass judging, or close-call resolution.      |
| Winners announced   | 15 July 2026           | Scores should be final before winner preparation begins.                                                              |

## How Judging Works

- Submissions are anonymised. Judges should evaluate by Reference ID only and avoid trying to identify teams.
- Each assigned submission should be reviewed using the submitted demo video, GitHub repository, ZIP/source files where needed, README/documentation, and any organiser-provided summary.
- Judging happens in passes. Pass 1 scores the assigned submissions. Pass 2 may re-score top submissions using a different set of judges to support final ranking.
- The platform may provide an AI-generated summary. Use it as a quick briefing only; it should not replace your own review of the project.
- Use drafts while still deciding. Submit final scores only when ready, because final submitted scores are locked.
- Written feedback is optional but helpful for organisers when scores are close or when a project has unusual strengths or issues.

## Recommended Review Flow

1. Watch the demo video first so you understand the intended user experience and the team's own explanation of the project.
2. Open the repository and README to check setup clarity, architecture, implementation depth, and whether the project appears complete.
3. Use the ZIP/source package if the repository is incomplete, if links are broken, or if a deeper code review is needed.
4. Score each category independently before looking too heavily at the weighted total.
5. Add a short note for organisers if a score needs context, if something appears broken, or if you see a possible rules or fairness issue.

## Scoring Rubric

Scores are weighted to produce a total out of 100. Use the full range: strong projects should be rewarded clearly, and weak or incomplete work should not receive middle scores by default.

| Category                  | Weight | What To Look For                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Technical Execution       | 25%    | Code quality, architecture, functionality, reliability, and how well the project actually works.                               |
| Innovation and Creativity | 20%    | Originality of the idea, creative problem-solving, and whether the team approached the theme in a memorable way.               |
| Security                  | 15%    | Secure coding practices, responsible data handling, sensible authentication/permissions, and consideration of abuse or misuse. |
| UX / UI                   | 15%    | User experience, visual clarity, ease of use, and whether the demo makes the value obvious.                                    |
| Documentation             | 15%    | Clear README, setup instructions, project explanation, and enough context for someone else to understand or run it.            |

| Category        | Weight | What To Look For                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Theme Relevance | 10%    | How well the project connects to World Cat Domination Day and supports positive impact for cats, owners, or the wider community. |

## Rating Guidance

| Rating  | Meaning       | Use When                                                                                       |
|---------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 stars | Exceptional   | The project is complete, clear, well-executed, and stands out strongly in that category.       |
| 4 stars | Strong        | The project performs well with only minor gaps or rough edges.                                 |
| 3 stars | Average       | The project meets the category at a basic level but has visible limitations.                   |
| 2 stars | Below average | The project makes an attempt but has significant issues, missing pieces, or unclear execution. |
| 1 star  | Poor          | The category is barely addressed, not demonstrated, or materially broken.                      |

## Fairness and Consistency Expectations

- Apply the same standard across all assigned projects, even when styles, tech stacks, or project sizes differ.
- Judge what was submitted by the deadline. Do not give extra credit for intentions that are not visible in the submitted materials.
- Smaller complete projects can score highly. Bigger projects should only score higher when the additional scope is actually working and well explained.

- Do not penalise participants for using AI tools, but originality, understanding, and implementation effort must still be evident.
- Avoid discussing specific scores, rankings, or team identities outside the organiser process.
- Escalate any conflict of interest, suspected plagiarism, broken submission, inaccessible link, or rules concern before submitting a final score.

## Security and Sponsor Tool Notes

Security is a scored category, not a separate audit. Judges should look for reasonable secure coding choices and responsible data handling based on the project scope.

- Aikido scan reports, if included, can support the Security score and may be considered for bonus credit within that category.
- A clean scan should not automatically produce a top Security score; judges should still consider architecture, exposed secrets, authentication, validation, and data handling.
- If a submitted security report seems inconsistent with the project, or if something looks materially unsafe, flag it to organisers and add context in the feedback box.

## What Coding Kitty Will Provide

- Access to assigned submissions through the judging system.
- The scoring rubric and category weights.
- Estimated project volumes and assignment expectations before or at the start of judging.
- A separate platform-use guide covering login, dashboard navigation, drafts, and score submission mechanics.
- Organiser support for broken links, access issues, conflicts of interest, or score/process questions.

## Quick Checklist Before Final Submission

- I watched the demo and checked the README or repository.
- I scored all six categories independently.
- I used the same standard I applied to other assigned projects.
- I added organiser feedback if the score needs explanation.
- I am ready for this score to be treated as final.

*Contact: use the organiser Discord channel or the hackathon organiser email if access, submission, conflict, or scoring issues come up during the judging window.*